

Chapter 54-2: 欲盖弥彰 (Trying to Cover Up Only Makes Things More Obvious)

"I'll go call for a medical immortal from the sect." Ning Fuyi said as she got up, but Chu Qingqiu grabbed her wrist and stopped her beside the bed.

"Don't let anyone know I'm injured!" Chu Qingqiu's voice grew heavier. She pulled Ning Fuyi back, her slender hand pointing to the low cabinet by the window, her voice calm, "Bring me the green bottle from inside."

Ning Fuyi had no choice but to comply. She opened the cabinet and saw an entire drawer full of medicine bottles.

She took out the green porcelain bottle, pulled out the cork, and picked up a crystal-clear pill. Then she went to find water and brought both the medicine and water to Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu was truly severely injured—she could barely hold the teacup steady, drinking half the water while spilling the other half.

Watching the water stains flow down from her lips, Ning Fuyi somehow got her wires crossed and naturally reached out, her fingertips brushing across those lips to wipe away the water.

When she realized what she had just done, both of them froze. Ning Fuyi quickly withdrew her hand, but the sensation of Chu Qingqiu's lips still lingered on the back of her hand.

Soft and elastic, completely contrary to her usual dignified bearing.

A blush rose on Ning Fuyi's face like steam. She stiffened and stood up, pretending to put the teacup back while actually trying to suppress her suddenly racing heart.

It wasn't for any other reason—she suddenly remembered the feeling of holding Chu Qingqiu earlier. Her water-soaked body had been just as soft and gentle as those lips.

Perhaps it was because she had suddenly grown taller, but Chu Qingqiu, who had once felt difficult to carry, now fit just right in her arms.

Behind her, Chu Qingqiu was equally unsettled. She bit down hard on her lip until she felt a sharp pain at the corner of her mouth.

That gesture had been too familiar—so familiar that she dreamed of it every night. She had yearned for it countless times in her dreams, driving herself to madness, only to force herself to forget upon waking.

Each lost in their own thoughts, they remained silent for a long time. Only then did Ning Fuyi compose herself and return to crouch halfway beside Chu Qingqiu's bed: "What happened?"

Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her: "The power within your body is very complex, as if two forces are constantly clashing, thus repelling all other divine consciousness."

Ning Fuyi thought of the two trees she had seen in the sea of consciousness.

"I was also careless." Chu Qingqiu said lightly.

Two forces? Could it be demonic energy? Ning Fuyi lowered her eyes in thought. Could it be that she still had the possibility of falling to the demonic path, but another force was suppressing it?

No wonder she couldn't cultivate demonic arts now and couldn't obtain the Emei Thorn¹. But where did this other force come from? She hadn't encountered any special opportunities in this lifetime.

"You must be careful in future cultivation. You must proceed step by step and not be reckless." Chu Qingqiu warned.

"Yes, Divine Venerable."

This topic came to an end. The pill seemed to have no effect—Chu Qingqiu's complexion grew worse. She turned her face toward the wall, fine sweat seeping from her neck and sticking to her dark hair.

"Chu Qingqiu?" In her urgency, Ning Fuyi called her by name and reached out to test her body temperature, only to be startled by the ice-cold touch.

Chu Qingqiu's body suddenly curled up slightly, as if sensing some pain. Sweat dampened the thin clothing on her shoulders, yet she shivered continuously from the cold.

"Wait!" Ning Fuyi had never cared for anyone before and felt panicked inside. However, her hands moved with surprising dexterity that even amazed herself—she casually pulled out a handkerchief to wipe her forehead, then drew the bedding over to cover her properly.

She even subconsciously wanted to sit on the bed and hold Chu Qingqiu's cold body in her arms for warmth. Fortunately, she caught herself before her body could act first.

What was happening? It was as if she had done this hundreds of times before.

"I'm still going to find a medical immortal. At worst, I'll erase her memory after she treats you!" Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to watch anymore. Murderous intent surged in her heart as she lifted her legs to leave.

"Come back!" Chu Qingqiu struggled to sit up and stop her, but Ning Fuyi moved quickly and had already reached the door. In the end, Chu Qingqiu could only raise her voice and shout her name sternly, finally calling her back.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu supported her body with difficulty, her hair falling over her shoulders, her eyes red underneath. "You never listen to what I say, do you!"

When Chu Qingqiu was angry, the area under her eyes would turn red. The redder and more obvious her eye corners became, the heavier her anger. Ning Fuyi had loved watching her eyes turn red when she tormented her in her previous life, so she knew this very well.

Ning Fuyi stopped abruptly. She turned back, wanting to argue with Chu Qingqiu. But seeing her struggling to maintain her composure, she couldn't bring herself to harbor any malicious thoughts.

So after the two of them faced off for a while, Ning Fuyi closed the door again.

"I'm afraid you'll die from the pain."

"Didn't you want me dead long ago?" Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice. Perhaps the pain was truly severe, for there was a rare note of grievance in her coldness. "Earlier in the cold pool, you wanted to kill me. Now that I'm dying, wouldn't that fulfill your wish!"

"Who said I want you to die?" Ning Fuyi frowned, the grief from her previous life—watching her loved ones leave one by one—suddenly seized her heart.

"I won't allow you to die." She said again, then walked to Chu Qingqiu's bedside and suddenly reached out to press her back onto the bed.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu was both shocked and angry, but when she looked up and met those cold phoenix eyes, she was momentarily lost.

The face that had shed its girlish innocence overlapped with the one in her memory. That face was extremely aggressive—when smiling, it was like a demon who cared about nothing; when not smiling, it always made one's heart race.

While she was in a daze, her chest garment had already been opened by Ning Fuyi. The cool breeze mixed with the sudden heat rising on her face, and Chu Qingqiu almost couldn't control her immortal power from blasting Ning Fuyi away.

Fortunately, she was a bit slow—the bone-cutting needle left by Jiang Li had already pierced into her body. After a moment of pain, her entire body went numb and tingly.

Her body went soft and fell backward, caught by Ning Fuyi's hand supporting her shoulder and back.

The copper nail-like piercing pain finally eased. Chu Qingqiu's body went completely limp in Ning Fuyi's arms. She wanted to push herself away from Ning Fuyi, but her consciousness gradually blurred. Finally, her eyelashes covered the redness and crystalline tears beneath her eyes as she quietly fell asleep.

Only then did Ning Fuyi breathe a sigh of relief. The medical arts of the Jiang clan from Wushan² were indeed miraculous. However, she had forgotten to ask Jiang Li how long this bone-cutting needle needed to be maintained, afraid that letting go would shift its position. So she maintained the posture of holding Chu Qingqiu around the waist until her arm grew slightly sore.

Suddenly, footsteps came from outside the door. Someone shouting "Master" rushed in in a panic. Upon seeing the scene in the room, the ancient divine jade they were holding clattered to the floor in pieces.

Ning Fuyi had that damned reflexive response again—she quickly pulled up the bedding to cover Chu Qingqiu. In Qiu Yi's³ eyes, this looked like trying to cover up after doing something wrong.

Thus, a grief-stricken scream echoed throughout the entire Jingshan Palace.

"Ahhhh!!"

Footnotes:

1. **峨眉刺 (Emei Thorn)** - A type of weapon associated with the Emei school of martial arts, typically a short, stabbing weapon.
2. **巫山 (Wushan)** - Literally "Witch Mountain," a location known for its medical practitioners in this story.
3. **秋亦 (Qiu Yi)** - Chu Qingqiu's disciple, whose name literally means "Autumn Too" or "Also Autumn."